

The Ash-Sealed Trial of Fenspire and Cindermere Hold

[The chamber doors groan shut. A clerk rises beneath the hanging iron seal.]

CLERK: Let the record hear the matter concerning Fenspire and Cindermere Hold. Let every tongue be measured, for the walls remember more than men do.

MAGISTRATE: Clerk, state the first holding.

CLERK: Fenspire stands in the Gloaming Reach. It was founded in 57 AS. It is a core location, and its garrisoned status remains. Its garrison is 3,742.

MAGISTRATE: Describe what stands there.

CLERK: Its silhouette is defined by a stark spire rising above the dim character of the Gloaming Reach. Fenspire projects disciplined vigilance. Its atmosphere is shaped by permanent military occupation.

[A low stir passes through the benches. I record it as fear, though it may have been only the wind beneath the doors.]

MAGISTRATE: And the second holding?

CLERK: Cindermere Hold was founded in 246 AS among The High Spires. Though its garrison once numbered 8878, the hold is now abandoned and is not a core holding.

MAGISTRATE: Describe its present aspect.

CLERK: Its abandoned silhouette combines the blackened severity of cinders with the elevated isolation of the High Spires. It conveys immense former strength hollowed into ruin.

COUNSEL: I object to “former strength.” Strength is not a witness.

MAGISTRATE: The objection is heard and dismissed. The clerk speaks from the standing description.

COUNSEL: Then let the standing description answer this: If Fenspire is garrisoned and Cindermere Hold abandoned, what law permits one to be set against the other?

MAGISTRATE: No law has yet been shown.

COUNSEL: The record itself shows the difference. Fenspire is a core location. Cindermere Hold is not a core holding. Fenspire has 3,742 in garrison. Cindermere Hold once numbered 8878. One is watched. One is hollow.

[The accused shifts. I cannot see the face beneath the ash-cloth, and therefore cannot swear whether the shifting was guilt.]

MAGISTRATE: Do not turn description into accusation.

COUNSEL: I turn nothing. The stones turn it for me.

MAGISTRATE: Stones do not testify.

CLERK: They do, in older trials.

[Silence. The magistrate fixes the clerk with a long look.]

MAGISTRATE: Strike that remark.

CLERK: Struck.

MAGISTRATE: The court recognizes the following: Fenspire stands in the Gloaming Reach, founded in 57 AS, a core location with a garrison of 3,742 and a garrisoned status. Cindermere Hold was founded in 246 AS among The High Spires; its garrison once numbered 8878, but it is now abandoned and is not a core holding.

[The seal is lowered. Judgment is reserved, as all judgments are when the dead have not finished speaking.]